Assessment (non-exam) Brief

UCL SCHOOL OF MANAGEMENT

Module code/name	MSIN0221 Natural Language Processing
Module leader name	Tjun Hoh
Academic year	2025/26
Term	2
Assessment title	Group Assignment
Individual/group assessment	Group

Submission deadlines: Students should submit all work by the published deadline date and time. Students experiencing sudden or unexpected events beyond your control which impact your ability to complete assessed work by the set deadlines may request mitigation via the extenuating circumstances procedure. Students with disabilities or ongoing, long-term conditions should explore reasonable academic adjustments. Students may use the delayed assessment scheme for pre-determined mitigation on a limited number of assessments in a year. Check the Delayed Assessment Scheme area on Portico to see if this assessment is eligible.

Return and status of marked assessments: Students should expect to receive feedback within 20 working days of their submission deadline, as per UCL guidelines. The module team will update you if there are delays through unforeseen circumstances (e.g. ill health). All results when first published are provisional until confirmed by the Examination Board.

Copyright Note to students: Copyright of this assessment brief is with UCL and the module leader(s) named above. If this brief draws upon work by third parties (e.g. Case Study publishers) such third parties also hold copyright. It must not be copied, reproduced, transferred, distributed, leased, licensed or shared with any other individual(s) and/or organisations, including web-based organisations, without permission of the copyright holder(s) at any point in time.

Academic Misconduct: Academic Misconduct is defined as any action or attempted action that may result in a student obtaining an unfair academic advantage. **Academic misconduct includes plagiarism, self-plagiarism, obtaining help from/sharing work with others be they individuals and/or organisations or any other form of cheating that may result in a student obtaining an unfair academic advantage.** Refer to Academic Manual Chapter 6, Section 9: Student Academic Misconduct Procedure - 9.2 Definitions.

Referencing: You must reference and provide full citation for ALL sources used, including articles, text books, lecture slides and module materials. This includes any direct quotes and paraphrased text. If in doubt, reference it. If you need further guidance on referencing please see UCL's referencing guide for students. Failure to cite references correctly may result in your work being referred to the Academic Misconduct Panel. For guidance on how to acknowledge the use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) please see next section.

Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) Tools in your Assessment: Your module leader will explain to you if and how AI tools can be used to support your assessment. In some assessments, the use of generative AI is **not permitted** at all. In others, AI may be used in an **assistive** role which means students are permitted to use AI tools to support the development of specific skills required for the assessment as specified by the module leader. In others, the use of AI tools may be an **integral** component of the assessment; in these cases the assessment will provide an opportunity to demonstrate effective and responsible use of AI. See page 3 of this brief to check which category use of AI falls into for this assessment. Students should refer to the UCL guidance on acknowledging use of AI and referencing AI. Failure to correctly acknowledge the use of AI in assessments may result in students being reported via the Academic Misconduct procedure. Refer to the section of the UCL Assessment success guide on Engaging with AI in your education and assessment.

Content of this assessment brief

Section	Content
A	Core information
B	Coursework brief and requirements
C	Additional information
D	Module learning outcomes covered in this assessment
E	Groupwork instructions (if applicable)
F	How your work is assessed

Section A: Core information

Submission date	31/03/2026
Submission time	Separate submission dates on 02/02/2026 [Project Proposal] and 31/03/2026 [Final Report & Presentation]. All submissions due by 10:00 am (UK time)
Assessment is marked out of:	100
% weighting of this assessment within total module mark	60%
Maximum word count/page length/duration	4,000
Footnotes, appendices, tables, figures, diagrams, charts included in/excluded from word count/page length?	Any footnotes, appendices, references, figures and tables' captions, are NOT included in the page limit.
Bibliographies, reference lists included in/excluded from word count/page length?	Title page, table of contents, any bibliography are NOT included in the page limit.
Penalty for exceeding maximum word count/number of pages specified above	Penalty for exceeding specified word count/number of pages will be a deduction of 10 percentage points, capped at 40% for Levels 4, 5, 6 and 50% for Level 7). Refer to Academic Manual: Module Assessment – Word Counts.
Penalty for late submission	Standard UCL penalties will apply. Students should refer to Academic Manual: Module Assessment – Deadlines and Late Assessment.
Artificial Intelligence (AI) category	Assistive
Submitting your assessment	The assessment MUST be submitted to the module submission link located within this module's Moodle 'Submissions' tab by the specified deadline. Please note that there are multiple submission points for this assessment.
Anonymity of identity. Normally, all submissions are anonymous unless the nature of the submission is such that anonymity is not appropriate, illustratively as in presentations or where minutes of group meetings are required as part of a group work submission	The nature of this assessment is such that anonymity is not required.
Feedback release date (Students with extended deadlines may receive feedback later; multiple extensions may delay feedback to the cohort; ill health in the marking team may delay feedback; students will be alerted to any delays.)	28/04/2026

Section B: Assessment Brief and Requirements

This group assignment will involve the delivery of an NLP project from conception to model delivery and analysis. This brief is intentionally kept vague, because the project needs to be motivated by your own interests. You should choose an NLP application domain that you find personally appealing.

Whatever domain you choose, pose the project as a specific question that at least potentially has an answer, such as:

- Can I profile what consumers think of my main competitors from their social media posts?
- How accurately can I attribute headlines to newspapers?
- What types of customer support questions could I apply state-of-the-art language models to, and where might they struggle?

Scope

Keep the project scope realistic: it is better to get properly to grips with a simpler question than take on something more ambitious that you struggle to complete. You can always add extra challenges later if it turns out to be too easy.

There are no dedicated computing resources allocated for projects, so consider how much you will be able to achieve computationally. You should probably not attempt to train GPT-5 or Claude from scratch!

You may use the DeepFlow platform for your project. It is also possible that you may be able to get some free compute hours on Microsoft Azure or Google Cloud if you haven't claimed them before. Google Colab (https://colab.research.google.com/) is another useful resource. Keep in mind that we are primarily interested in the motivation behind your idea, the approach taken, understanding of the process and derived learnings rather than absolute model performance.

Data and Models

You are free to use any data sources you can (legally) find, as well as existing model implementations and pre-trained weights, as long as all sources are credited. You do need to add something of your own, however. It is not sufficient to simply go through the process of getting an existing model implementation running locally on its own examples (though doing so can also be instructive).

Data, especially labelled data, tends to be a significant bottleneck for deep learning applications. If you have an interesting question but are unable address it because the requisite data simply isn't available, see if you can reframe it in terms of more standard data sources. For example, can you achieve something equivalent with commonly used sources like the Stanford Sentiment Treebank or SQuAD (Stanford Question Answering Dataset)? Can you leverage a small amount of domain-specific data by fine-tuning a pre-trained model? Can you learn a proxy task for which data is easily synthesised?

If not, can you manually (maybe with the help of family and friends) label a small subset of data as the basis of a proof of concept?

Organisation

The project is to be undertaken in small groups of three to five members.

The project is organised in terms of the following milestones:

1. **Project Proposal:** This should be a short report stating the application domain and framing your research question. Provide a brief indication of your initial thoughts on how to approach it and a short summary of relevant background material. Include a project plan outlining the tasks that need to be performed and include a Gantt Chart (or similar visual evidence of project

management) with target dates. Note key resources that will be used such as potential datasets, models, sample code, and pre-trained weights – all with appropriate references.

   a. **Page limit:** maximum 3 content pages
   b. **Due date:** by the initial proposal deadline as indicated (02/02/2026)
   c. **Percentage of project grade:** 25%

2. **Final Report:** Outline the background for the project, what you did or failed to do, and present the answer, if you found one, to the originally posed question. We recommend structuring this report similarly to a scientific paper (Introduction, Methods, Results, Error Analysis & Discussion), but you may use a different structure if it seems more appropriate. We would suggest structuring the project report as the PDF output of a Jupyter Notebook or a LaTeX document following an existing research conference template (e.g. ARR, ACL, ICLR, etc). Note that your project must be reproducible -- this means that alongside your report, you must provide relevant code and data.
   a. **Page limit:** as indicated by the project word count specification
   b. **Due date:** by the final project deadline as indicated (31/03/2026)
   c. **Percentage of project grade:** 50%

3. **Presentation:** Provide a 5-minute recorded presentation (as you might be expected to present at a conference) of your key findings.
   a. **Time limit:** 5 minutes (+/- 30 seconds)
   b. **Due date:** by the final project deadline as indicated (31/03/2026)
   c. **Percentage of project grade:** 25%

For group projects, milestones should be submitted collectively, not individually.

Section C: Additional information from module leader (as appropriate)

Marking Criteria – *Project Proposal (25%)*

- Clear and challenging rationale underlying chosen research question and application domain.
- Coherent summary of background material.
- Realistic and actionable project plan and Gantt Chart.
- Appropriate selection and demonstrable understanding of key resources required.
- Potential limitations and risks are identified and reasonably justified.

Marking Criteria – *Final Report (50%)*

Structure and Format (5%)

- Provides a concise summary.
- Coherent and appropriate structure.
- Adequate presentation, language, style, graphs, tables, and referencing.
- Appropriate use of visualisation

Methodology & Analysis (30%)

- Clear description of datasets or key resources used.
- Detailed methodology facilitating replication of the project and reproducibility of results.
- In-depth analysis and interpretations drawing on knowledge of relevant theories and their limitations.
- Robust validation testing and understanding of key evaluation metrics.
- Demonstrably innovative and insightful approach.

Quality of Narrative (10%)

- Clear, concise, and objective exposition.
- Demonstrates critical thinking and an understanding of the application domain.
- Research question is clearly identified and boundaries are asserted.
- Limitations and risks are identified and justified by reasonable arguments.
- Conclusions are fully consistent with evidence presented.

Code / Equations / Referencing / Citations (5%)

- Code provided is well-structured and clearly annotated.
- Correct referencing of publicly-sourced code.
- Concise and appropriate use of mathematical notation.
- Clear referencing of third-party tools including generative AI tools.
- Demonstration of relevant literature and technical resources where appropriate.

Marking Criteria – *Presentation (25%)*

- Clear and engaging presentation within the allocated time limit.
- Appropriate use of visualisations and well-chosen content.
- Clear explanation of project motivations and journey.
- Convincing demonstration of NLP project and key findings within an applied context.
- Logical arguments and conclusions supported by evidence, with actionable recommendations for future work

Section D: Module Learning Outcomes covered in this Assessment

This assessment contributes towards the achievement of the following stated module Learning Outcomes as highlighted below:

- Be aware of the opportunities for using Natural Language Processing for common tasks
- Understand methods for handling and preprocessing textual data
- Understand metrics for evaluating model performance
- Be capable of delivering a Natural Language Processing project from conception to model development and error analysis
- Be aware of current state-of-the-art methods and limitations

Section E: Groupwork Instructions (where relevant/appropriate)

- Groups are to have between three to five members
- Groups will be selected by students
- All group members are expected to actively and equally contribute to the assignment
- The first page of the report must include a breakdown of member contribution, i.e. which group members were responsible for which sections of the assignment

Section F: How your work is assessed

Within each section of this assessment you may be assessed on the following aspects, as applicable and appropriate to this assessment, and should thus consider these aspects when fulfilling the requirements of each section:

- The accuracy of any calculations required.
- The strengths and quality of your overall analysis and evaluation;
- Appropriate use of relevant theoretical models, concepts and frameworks;
- The rationale and evidence that you provide in support of your arguments;
- The credibility and viability of the evidenced conclusions/recommendations/plans of action you put forward;
- Structure and coherence of your considerations and reports;
- Appropriate and relevant use of, as and where relevant and appropriate, real world examples, academic materials and referenced sources. Any references should use either the Harvard OR Vancouver referencing system (see References, Citations and Avoiding Plagiarism)
- Academic judgement regarding the blend of scope, thrust and communication of ideas, contentions, evidence, knowledge, arguments, conclusions.
- Each assessment requirement(s) has allocated marks/weightings.

Student submissions are reviewed/scrutinised by an internal assessor and are available to an External Examiner for further review/scrutiny before consideration by the relevant Examination Board.

It is not uncommon for some students to feel that their submissions deserve higher marks (irrespective of whether they actually deserve higher marks). To help you assess the relative strengths and weaknesses of your submission please refer to SOM Assessment Criteria Guidelines. This information is also located on the Assessment tab of the SOM Student Information Centre Moodle site (Moodle log in required).
The above is an important link as it specifies the criteria for attaining the pass/fail bandings shown below:
At UG Levels 4, 5 and 6:
80% to 100%: Outstanding Pass - 1st; 70% to 79%: Excellent Pass - 1st; 60%-69%: Very Good Pass - 2.1; 50% to 59%: Good Pass - 2.2; 40% to 49%: Satisfactory Pass - 3rd; 20% to 39%: Insufficient to Pass - Fail; 0% to 19%: Poor and Insufficient to Pass - Fail.
At PG Level 7:
86% to 100%: Outstanding Pass - Distinction; 70% to 85%: Excellent Pass - Distinction; 60%-69%: Good Pass - Merit; 50% to 59%: Satisfactory - Pass; 40% to 49%: Insufficient to Pass - Fail; 0% to 39%: Poor and Insufficient to Pass - Fail.

You are strongly advised to review these criteria **before you start your work** and **during your work**, and **before you submit**.

Upon receipt of your mark, you are strongly advised to **not** compare your mark with marks of other submissions from your student colleagues. Each submission has its own range of characteristics which differ from others in terms of breadth, scope, depth, insights, and subtleties and nuances. On the surface one submission may appear to be similar to another but invariably, digging beneath the surface reveals a range of differing characteristics.

Students who wish to request a review of a decision made by the Board of Examiners should refer to the UCL Academic Appeals Procedure, taking note of the acceptable grounds for such appeals.
Note that the purpose of this procedure is not to dispute academic judgement – it is to ensure correct application of UCL's regulations and procedures. The appeals process is evidence-based and circumstances must be supported by independent evidence.